

# Chapter 4

## Revolutionary terrorism

Il n'y a pas d'innocents.

Émile Henry, 1894

Eugene V. Walter's second category of political violence, the 'siege of terror', represents the way in which terrorism is most commonly conceived: as an assault on the state. From this perspective we can see emerging in the 19th century an increasingly well-defined strategy in which terror forms the central—indeed, in its purest form, the exclusive—method. The word 'revolutionary' has been applied over the last century in three distinct kinds of social-political contexts: within existing nation-states; in external colonial situations; and in 'internal colonial' situations where one or more ethnic groups are oppressed by a majority group within a single (or not easily divisible) 'homeland'. But the criteria for truly revolutionary change—social transformation, or at least major social and economic change—are generally fulfilled only in the first of these circumstances. In cases where ethnic identity rather than progressive ideology is the driving force, resistance movements can be remarkably conservative—if not indeed reactionary. In this chapter and the next, these contrasting motives and goals will be explored.

Once again, the definition of revolution itself is not straightforward. Some writers prefer to set out a spectrum of revolutionary aims and outcomes, ranging from total social transformation to change of the ruling general or dictator—the so-called 'palace revolution'. Now and again there are revolutions from the top—*coups d'état*—but the common sense of the concept relates to political action

from outside the incumbent power structure. A sensible general definition might be ‘the attempt to seize political power from the established regime of a state, to bring about fundamental political and social change’.

## Two ages of terrorism: 1

Terrorism with this aim emerged as a consistent and coherent strategy in the late 19th century. We need to recognize that this kind of terrorism was qualitatively new, a phenomenon essentially distinct from political assassination as practised continuously throughout history; not so much because of new technology or methods, but because modern terrorists had a different view of their role, of society, and of the significance of their actions. The concept of ‘individual terror’ is a key indicator of the modern age of violence. The label was pejorative, admittedly; it was attached to this form of terror in the early 20th century, a while after its heyday, by the Bolsheviks—who disapproved not of the violence as such but the individualism, the ‘voluntarism’ of the Socialist Revolutionary (SR) terrorist strategy in Tsarist Russia. Marx and Engels themselves were oddly vague in their use of the concept of terror; they often conflated it with force or violence in general, which seems to be what Marx had in mind when he said that ‘revolutionary terrorism’ was the only way to shorten the ‘agonies of the old society and the birth pangs of the new’. Lenin was more careful, and produced an interesting definition of terrorism as ‘single combat’ in contrast to mass action. He branded terrorist campaigns as nonsensical, because such individual acts of violence were ‘unconnected with the mass of the people’.

This view, albeit hostile, highlights the essence of the phenomenon that evolved through the parallel activities of anarchists, populists, and syndicalists, as well as nihilists in Lenin’s youth. Though few of them acted absolutely alone, they were certainly very small groups with very big ideas about the recasting of society. They believed that individuals could change the course of history. They did not major on the term ‘terror’, though the leading theoretician of armed action in the *Narodnaya Volya* (People’s Will), Nikolai Morozov, accepted the phrase ‘terroristic warfare’ on the grounds that this was an expression adopted by the people. The SR party programme in 1879 talked of ‘destructive and terroristic activity’. But many alternative terms were used, some more or less euphemistic: Morozov advocated the term ‘neo-partisan warfare’ (with its echoes of the great patriotic struggle of 1812 against Napoleon), while the anarchists adopted the striking formula of ‘propaganda by deed’, Pilsudski’s Polish Socialists called it

the ‘armed deed’, and syndicalists ‘direct action’, or *reprise individuelle*.

The notion of propaganda by deed, first described by the Italian Federation of the Anarchist International in 1876, is a good place to start, because it vividly displays the underlying logic of so much terrorist action. The ‘insurrectionary deed’, ‘designed to promote the principles of socialism by action’, was (the Italian anarchists suggested) ‘the most efficient means of propaganda and the one most capable of breaking through to the deepest social strata’. The idea of economy of means—very appealing to organizations too cash-strapped to exploit the conventional media of communication—is prominent here. In any case, the level of general literacy in 19th-century Europe imposed sharp limitations on conventional propaganda, as the French anarchist Paul Brousse lucidly argued the following year (1877) when he said that propaganda by deed could show ‘the weary and inert masses ... that which they were unable to read, teach them socialism in practice, make it visible, tangible, concrete’.

Though Errico Malatesta’s original instrument of violent propaganda was insurrection rather than terrorism, repeated failures of insurrectionist attempts in Italy and elsewhere throughout the 19th century pointed unmistakably in the direction of the latter. And if we ask how death and destruction could ‘teach’ socialism, Prince Peter Kropotkin, the most rational and humane of the Russian anarchists (generally a rational and humane lot), thought he had a persuasive explanation. ‘Actions which compel general attention’ led the new idea to ‘seep into people’s minds’. A single act could ‘in a few days, make more propaganda than thousands of pamphlets’, and:

Above all, it awakens the spirit of revolt; it breeds daring ... Soon it becomes apparent that the established order does not have the strength often supposed ... The people observe that the monster is not so terrible as they thought ...

This effect, Kropotkin believed, would be strengthened rather than negated as the regime reacted with ‘savage repressions’—which would ‘provoke new acts of revolt, individual and collective, driving the rebels to heroism’. At the same time, Kropotkin was fiercely critical of random individual terror, cautioning that ‘a structure based on centuries of history cannot be destroyed with a few kilograms of explosives’.

Despite this reservation, the central threads of the logic of revolutionary

terrorism can be seen in Kropotkin's analysis. First, the power of the violent act not only to attract attention but also to convey quite a complex political message; second, the potential receptivity of 'the people', the masses or the workers, to the message, the assumption that their revolutionary awareness will accelerate as soon as 'the scales drop from their eyes'; and, finally, the inevitability of a spiral of provocation and reaction that will radicalize the masses and eventually mobilize them into action against the government. This logic was embraced by both anarchists and populists, and imposed a number of strict conditions on the behaviour of terrorists. To delegitimize the state, revolutionaries had to select targets that would be perceived as legitimate by the people. To impress and convert the people, the revolutionaries must display the highest moral qualities—the 'heroism' referred to by Kropotkin. (There may also have been a streak of elitism here; terrorist action would keep the revolution under the control of the educated minority.)

Terrorist activity, as announced by the *Narodniki* (Populists) in 1879, began with careful targeting. It had two modes: 'the destruction of the most harmful persons in the government, and the punishment of official lawlessness and violence', and also 'the protection of the Party from spies'. Its aim was 'to break down the prestige of government' and 'to raise the revolutionary spirit in the people, and finally to form a body suited and accustomed to warfare'. Acquiring military skills and familiarity with high explosives was important to the ultimate outcome of the revolutionary struggle, but it was subordinate to the moral qualities of individual revolutionaries in the thinking of the *Narodniki*. Peter Lavrov's essay on 'The Social Revolution and the Tasks of Morality' (1884) put this clearly: 'We need energetic, utterly dedicated people, prepared to gamble all, to sacrifice everything. We need martyrs ...' Because those using violence had 'no right to endanger the moral stance of the socialist struggle', he insisted, 'not one unnecessary drop of blood shall be spilled'. The justification, indeed the necessity, of armed action seemed self-evident in Tsarist Russia. Alexander Ulyanov (Lenin's elder brother), who was arrested and executed in 1887 for his part in the planned assassination of Tsar Alexander III by a fringe group, the terrorist faction of the *Narodnaya Volya*, explained to his distraught—and highly respectable—mother, 'What can I do, mother, if there is no other way?'

The next generation of terrorists, the Combat Organization of the Socialist Revolutionary Party, stuck to these ideals. (Though, sadly for the Party, the Organization was run by a government double agent.) Grigori Gershuni said that

for the SRs, ‘anyone who does not demonstrate opposition to the crimes of the regime becomes by virtue of this fact an accomplice in their crimes’. But he still did not make this a charter for indiscriminate terror. He insisted that attacks had to be seen as just acts of retribution by the people, expressions of their true aspirations; ‘only a revolutionary party which does not breach the revolutionary morality contains the force of life’. Most importantly, he gave an especially rapt expression to the essential belief of terrorists in their power to transform the world: ‘Only a scientist who discovers a new law of the universe experiences a similar feeling, since this enables him to turn from slave to master of the universe.’ Thinking of a prisoner who resists the worst torture, he demanded ‘has he not subdued all the universe to his spirit?’ ‘A socialist party can win only by moral integrity, not by physical predominance.’

The most celebrated exemplar of this strict moral stance was Ivan Kaliayev, the assassin of Grand Duke Sergei, who refused to throw his bomb when he saw that the prince’s family was in the carriage with him (though he succeeded in killing him in a later, suicidal attempt). Assassination remained the lodestar for these revolutionaries, who preserved for a generation the belief that, as one of the assassins of Tsar Alexander II recorded, the Tsar’s death would be ‘the final awful blow ... It will deal a mighty blow to that system which some sly souls call “absolute monarchy” but which we ourselves call tyranny.’

Gradually, though, it became clear that the original logic of the ‘blow at the centre’ was flawed. Tsar followed assassinated tsar, and the supply of candidates to become chief of police showed no sign of drying up, however often they were attacked. Though anarchists ceaselessly picked over the vulnerabilities of the state’s lines of communication, the sad truth seemed to be that the most repressive states were the least vulnerable to terrorist attack—precisely because there public opinion was politically insignificant. Democracies were far more sensitive, but high-minded terrorists excluded them from their list of targets. At the fifth SR conference in 1909, the party’s principal theoretician, Chernov, worried that ‘we must not allow routine to set in. Terror is a form of military combat, a form of war.’ In war, Chernov said, states whose military methods were outdated exposed themselves to defeat, so in internal warfare ‘we must master modern techniques’ if terror was to remain ‘terror in the true sense of the word’. Here was the origin of a process of self-deception, continuing over the next century, in which revolutionary terrorists disguised the implications of failure by continually appealing to the possibilities of new and more destructive

technology.

In the wave of anarchist terror that swept the Western world around the turn of the century, it was already clear that one compensatory mechanism was to abandon restraints on targeting choice. For anarchists, the distinction between despotic and liberal-democratic states was illusory: the enemy of human freedom was the state itself. Following the doctrine of ‘anarchist vengeance’ proclaimed by the exiled German anarchist Johannes Most in his paper *Freiheit* in London and then New York through the 1880s, anarchists slid away from Russian notions of tyranny and attacked the representatives of liberal states. In 1893, Auguste Vaillant threw a bomb into the French Chamber of Deputies, which he denounced as ‘corrupt’. (Perhaps after the Panama Scandal French public opinion may have been inclined to agree. Although Vaillant failed to kill any of his targets, he became an anarchist martyr, who had ‘never stolen or killed’.) But the promiscuous spread of killing seemed ever more nihilistic. The French Republic’s president, Sadi Carnot, was assassinated by an Italian anarchist exile, Santo Caserio, in 1894; and, in 1901, President McKinley of the USA was killed by a Pole. Indeed, anarchist terrorism was as active in the USA as anywhere: Most’s exhortation to ‘murder the murderers’ found plenty of outlets in the struggle of workers to organize in the face of ruthless strikebreaking action by employers.

Still more indiscriminate targets were also chosen. In 1893, the Liceo Theatre in Barcelona was bombed and twenty of the audience killed. The defining rationale, ‘there are no innocents’—at least among the bourgeoisie—was coined the following year by the French anarchist Émile Henry after hurling a bomb into a Paris café. The young shoemaker Léon-Jules Léauthier at the same time declared ‘I shall not strike an innocent if I strike the first bourgeois I meet’; ‘Would it make any difference which *bourgeois* one throws the bomb at?’, a Russian anarchist asked rhetorically in 1907.

## Two ages of terrorism: 2

After a generation in which terrorism seemed to be engulfing the world, it suddenly went out of style. (Annual totals of SR terrorist incidents in Russia, for instance, dropped from fifty-one, seventy-eight, and sixty-two in 1905–7 to three, two, and one in 1908–10.) The climactic act of the first age of terrorism,

the Sarajevo assassination (discussed in [Chapter 5](#)), launched the war that pushed terrorism back to the sidelines of political action. For instance, James Connolly, the only socialist among Irish revolutionaries, who set up a fighting organization in 1913 (the Irish Citizen Army), seems never to have considered adopting a terrorist strategy. He wrote combative essays on ‘street fighting’ which paid lip-service to modern technology, but fundamentally harked back to the days of the popular ‘barricade revolutions’ of the 19th century. The haemorrhage of the First World War seems to have drained Western society’s capacity for shock. The decline of anarchism, and the replacement of the SRs in Russia by the Bolshevik regime, redrew the paradigm of revolutionary action. The doctrine of ‘protracted war’ developed by Mao Zedong in China during the 1930s contained no role—in theory at any rate—for terrorism.

Aside from sporadic and often desultory campaigns like those of the IRA in the late 1930s and 1950s, terrorism as a freestanding strategy was absorbed into larger scale revolutionary movements which, whatever their official labels, were essentially nationalist mobilizations. Most of the resistance movements during the Second World War were fighting national struggles; and few people, apart from the Germans, described resistance fighters as terrorists. (In a notable study of partisan operations, the word ‘terrorism’ appeared only as a description of German antipartisan methods.) After the war, Marxist revolutionary movements proliferated, but their basis often remained national. The Malayan People’s Liberation Army, for instance, whose members were curtly labelled ‘Communist Terrorists’ (CTs) by the British authorities, failed to extend its revolutionary appeal beyond the marginalized Chinese community in Malaya. Though its leadership was certainly communist, it could not construct the kind of cross-ethnic class solidarity which Marxist revolutionary theory required. Here, as elsewhere in the postwar world, the threat of ‘communism’ which so terrified the First World, if it existed at all, lay almost entirely in the dynamism and discipline of the communist parties, rather than in the mass appeal of their ideas.

Two of these revolutionary wars, however, had an immense impact reaching far beyond the normal bilateral imperial nexus. The first and longest was in Vietnam, whose war of independence stretched from the closing months of the Second World War through into the 1960s. In the process, it sparked a dramatic upsurge of political dissent in the West, connecting a new revolutionary generation to the struggles of the Third World. The second was in Cuba, where a small band of revolutionaries succeeded in overthrowing the US-dominated



government in an astonishingly rapid rural guerrilla campaign between 1958 and 1961. A third conflict, the slow-burning struggle of the Palestinian Arabs to recover from and reverse the disaster of 1948, also played a key part in the rebirth of terrorism: here the turning point was the second ‘disaster’, the war of 1967, which placed the whole of Palestine under Israeli control.

Though terrorism was a significant element in both the Vietnam and Cuban wars, it was definitely subordinated to the logic of guerrilla warfare. In a systematic and ruthless campaign to eliminate collaboration, the Vietminh assassinated hundreds of village elders, together with anyone who cooperated with (or gave information to) the French authorities; altogether it and its successor the Vietcong may have killed 20,000 people in this way. For its part, Castro’s rebel band, though minuscule in comparison with the Vietminh forces, likewise systematically ‘executed’ suspected informers—what Che Guevara called ‘revolutionary justice’—to ensure its own survival. But this aspect of the Cuban experience was barely visible in the short handbook Che Guevara published in the euphoric period after Castro took power, *Guerrilla Warfare* (1961)—probably the most inspirational revolutionary tract of the century. A generation’s attention was seized by Guevara’s insistence that dedicated fighters could form a ‘*foco insurreccional*’ which would create a revolutionary situation. This stood orthodox Marxism on its head—a point hammered home in a more intellectual manner by Régis Debray (then a university teacher in Havana) in his equally celebrated *Revolution in the Revolution?* (1967)—and instantly threatened the old (in all senses) communist parties with irrelevance.

## The Latin American link

The link between the Guevara–Debray theory of revolution and the return to terrorism may not seem obvious. But the next step followed almost naturally, as the Cuban revolutionary example resonated across Latin America. A leading example is the self-reinvention of the Brazilian communist leader Carlos Marighela, a Party stalwart until 1967 when he went to the Conference of the Organization for Latin American Solidarity in Havana, about the time Guevara himself was killed in his failed rural insurgency in Bolivia. In the brief period between founding the Revolutionary Communist Party in early 1968 and his death in a gunfight with Brazilian police in November 1969, Marighela embraced another inspirational concept, the ‘urban guerrilla’. (The term was coined by a Spanish exile in Uruguay, Abraham Guillén, in his *Strategy of the*



*Urban Guerrilla* of 1966.) Marighela's June 1969 *Minimanual of the Urban Guerrilla*, which reached a much wider audience, shifted the revolutionary focus back to the cities, but in a very different style from the tenets of classical Marxism.

Its opening sentence—'Anyone who opposes the military dictatorship and wants to fight against it can do something, however little'—set its practical tone; and its treatment of terrorism (though surprisingly brief) reflected its opportunist spirit. Marighela first listed terrorism as one among fourteen 'methods of action', and defined it quite narrowly—'By terrorism I mean the use of bomb attacks'—but immediately went on to include looting stocks of food for the benefit of the people. ('In the work of revolutionary terrorism the guerrilla must always be adaptable.') In an essay on 'Guerrilla Tactics', he made clear that 'terrorism alone will not win us power', but could 'demoralize the authorities'. 'Revolutionary terrorism's great weapon is initiative which guarantees its survival ... The more committed terrorists there are, the more military power will be worn down, the more fear and tension it will suffer. ...' But he insisted that terrorist acts were 'not designed to kill members of the common people, or to upset or intimidate them in any way'. Marighela was certainly not blind to the moral problems involved in all this, but he insisted that 'It is better to act mistakenly than do nothing for fear of doing wrong.' The ultimate guarantee could only be the moral superiority of the individual guerrilla, produced by the fact that he is 'defending a just cause, the cause of the people'.

Even then, the adoption of indiscriminate terror was still a little way off. The first serious efforts to take guerrilla warfare into the city, in Venezuela and Guatemala from 1963 to 1967, preserved the essential operating logic of rural guerrilla action. The Tactical Combat Units set up by the recently united Venezuelan Armed Forces of National Liberation (FALN) in 1963 were each about a hundred strong (with supporting services in addition), though they divided more flexibly into 'shock units'. They briefly established 'liberated zones'. But they did not secure public support; indeed, their policy of assassinating policemen—all members of extended working-class Caracas families—had the opposite effect, and the Liberation Front suffered a serious defeat in the elections of 1964. In Guatemala, the quasi-Trotskyist Armed Rebel Forces led by Yon Sosa and Turcios Lima initially went in for what might be called armed education rather than propaganda by deed—they occupied villages and put on classes in socialist ideas—but in Guatemala City, their campaign

consisted mainly of abduction and assassination, and degenerated into a sterile vendetta with security forces and vigilante counterterror groups.

Perhaps the most resonant of all Latin American urban guerrilla campaigns emerged in the most democratic state south of the USA—Uruguay (once known as ‘the Switzerland of South America’), with one of the region’s highest standards of living. But Uruguay was in a prolonged economic crisis during the 1960s, with exports falling and inflation rising. The socialist-led insurgency followed the Guevarist model of starting from small beginnings. The Movement for National Liberation (MLN), universally known as the Tupamaros after the last independent Indian leader, Tupac Amaru (d. 1781), began operations in 1963 with a raid on a rifle club, and then spent a year preparing a cellular organization and studying Guillén’s work. After that, they launched a series of operations designed to enrol public support, notably the revolutionary ‘expropriations’ and food distribution carried out by the ‘hunger commando’. The climax of this campaign was the October 1969 occupation of the town of Pando near Montevideo, a brilliant publicity stunt and ‘homage to Che Guevara’ on the second anniversary of his death. Less spectacular, and ultimately more problematic, was a series of kidnappings of US diplomats and businessmen, designed to focus attention on American imperialism (though they also held the British ambassador Geoffrey Jackson for eight months in 1971).

At this time, the Tupamaros seemed to be living the revolutionary dream: they had secured widespread public acceptance of their critique of the established order, and support for their operations. Not until 1972 did Uruguay’s president declare a state of internal war, but after that the rapid shift to an increasingly authoritarian response—including the dissolution of parliament in June 1973—successfully carried public opinion with it. Between 1971 and September 1972, the proportion of the public who thought the Tupamaros were pursuing social justice fell from 59 per cent to 4 per cent, despite the crumbling of the liberal constitution (press censorship and detention without trial were introduced) under pressure from the military—who ironically had discovered that some Tupamaro allegations of governmental corruption were true, and (as so often elsewhere) moved in to clean up the state administration. More vigorous ‘antiterrorist’ measures succeeded in breaking up an organization that had become more vulnerable; in its confidence that it could move on to open confrontation with the army, it had let its earlier tight security slip in favour of expansion. The end result was a far more illiberal state, and less social justice.

The verdict on urban guerrilla action was ultimately negative. A level-headed overall assessment of its benefits and costs, by the military analyst Anthony Burton in his 1975 book *Urban Terrorism*, is worth quoting:

By huddling close to the enemy and the people, the former's superior firepower may be negated and the latter's revolutionary consciousness heightened. Central command and control is achieved and the articulation of political and military action, of strikes and demonstrations with armed attack, is made easier.

(We might add the high sensitivity of the government and the media to armed action in the capital city.) On the other hand,

a city-centred strategy is unlikely by itself to succeed: the effort is difficult to sustain, problems of security and logistics become crucial, and the support of the people is likely to be lost if they are asked to hide and succour the terrorist over a long period with no apparent prospect of success against a patient and determined government.

A way of sidestepping that was to go underground, and finance the organization by 'expropriations', that is, bank robberies. Marighela had advocated these partly as tactical exercises for training and sustaining urban 'firing groups'; and it was the underground group that was to be the vehicle for the dramatic return of revolutionary terrorism to 'the West' in the late 1960s. (Box 4.)

#### **Box 4**

We believe that carrying out armed struggle will affect the people's consciousness of the nature of the struggle against the state. By beginning the armed struggle, the awareness of its necessity will be furthered. This is no less true in the US than in other countries throughout the world. Revolutionary action generates revolutionary consciousness; growing consciousness develops revolutionary action. Action teaches the lessons of fighting and demonstrates that armed struggle is possible.

Weather Underground, *Prairie Fire* (1974)

As early as 1970, the re-emergence of terrorism was evident enough for Ted Robert Gurr, a leading analyst of rebellion, to sketch the 'conventional wisdom' about terrorism among most officials and ordinary people in Western societies (and quite a few experts, he added) as a relatively new and particularly threatening form of political violence, resorted to especially by alienated, youthful members of the middle class, and increasing rapidly throughout the world. Gurr demonstrated that as generalizations, all these propositions were false; adding that ironically 'this particular fantasy of the revolutionary Left has been accepted as an ominous political reality by everyone else'. The data he used to map the characteristics of 'political terrorism in the 1960s' already showed 4,455 deaths resulting from terrorist campaigns and 167 from isolated terrorist 'episodes' between 1961 and 1970. Though only 245 deaths from campaigns and twenty-six from episodes were in Europe, as against 1,630/ninety-two in Africa and Asia, and 2,580/forty-eight in Latin America, Gurr found that the totals of terrorist incidents and campaigns were greater in democratic than in autocratic political systems—105 incidents, seventy-two campaigns in democratic countries, as compared to twenty-one incidents and twenty-one campaigns in autocracies. He suggested that 'terrorists *can* act with more impunity in quasi-open societies than in police states'. But he thought that terrorism was 'principally the tactic of groups that represent the interests and demands of small minorities'—not, in fact, revolutionary movements.

The wave of terrorist action was surprisingly widespread: even Britain witnessed the brief flurry of the loosely anarchist Angry Brigade (twenty-seven bombs and a number of bank robberies between 1968 and 1971), while the USA puzzled over the Weathermen—who aimed at 'forcing the disintegration of society'—and the inscrutable Symbionese Liberation Army—which vaulted to amazing celebrity by kidnapping and enrolling the publishing heiress Patty Hearst for a San Francisco bank robbery, but whose fight for 'oppressed minorities everywhere' was too diffuse to strike a chord with the public. Such causes emerged again in Belgium and France, where *Action Directe* set out as late as 1979 'to wreck society through direct action by destroying its institutions and the men who serve it', and later targeted 'the Americanization of Europe'. But the most disconcerting upsurges of terror were in Germany and, above all, Italy, where between 1969 and 1980 there were 12,690 incidents of terrorist violence, killing 362 people and wounding 4,524. Such violence seemed to suggest the possibility of social breakdown in the most advanced societies.

## Groupuscular terrorism

The 1970s seemed to be the age of the ‘groupuscules’, the tiny, fissiparous radical activist groups which multiplied across Western Europe. In Italy, no fewer than 597 terrorist groups (of both left and right) were counted, but one above all appeared to challenge and subvert most deeply held Western liberal assumptions, and pose most acutely the issue of terrorist motivation—the BR (see [Chapter 1](#)), formed in 1969. Their first violent actions, armed robberies (‘proletarian expropriations’) and the firebombing of cars and theatres, began in November 1970. The BR habitually signed their communiqués ‘for communism’; their self-description was ‘autonomous worker organizations that indicate the first moments of proletarian self-organization to fight the bosses and their henchmen with the same means that they use against the working class’. This suggested, however, at best an indirect relationship with the proletariat, and students played a leading role in the adoption of violent methods. The by-now venerable tradition of Italian anarchism—and the example of neo-fascist terrorism also grimly in evidence during the 1960s—supplied the model. (A major early influence was the anarchist publisher Giangiacomo Feltrinelli, who died in a bomb misfire in 1972.) Student activism had been screwed up to an intense pitch by the virtual collapse of the university system, carrying a vast student population (over a million) and chronically underfunded. This crisis reflected the wider Italian social problem precipitated by an unsustainable shift of population from the countryside to the cities, and consequently spiralling unemployment.

The crisis of national confidence worsened through the 1970s under the impact of the 1973 oil supply crisis, while terrorist violence multiplied from 467 attacks in 1975 and 685 in 1976 through 1,806 in 1977 to 2,725 in 1978. The state’s perceived effectiveness and legitimacy continued to decline, and the number of Italians, particularly students, sympathetic to the terrorist movement became ‘shockingly large’. The BR’s emergence as the leading terrorist group during this period was confirmed when they mounted the spectacular kidnapping and eventual killing of Aldo Moro, a past and likely future prime minister who was a lynchpin of the fragile political system which depended on coalition-building. As a Christian Democrat (DC) leader, he figured in BR language as the ‘godfather’ of the ‘imperialist counter-revolution organized by the DC’, so he was a legitimate target at any time; but the timing of his abduction was determined by the approaching trial of key BR leaders in custody in Turin. His

five bodyguards were killed in an operation so precisely executed that many people insisted it must be the work of foreigners; alternatively, low national self-esteem could be confirmed by pointing to the incompetence of Moro's security arrangements—no bullet-proof car; fixed daily routine. At this stage, the Piedmontese capital, flooded with police and *carabinieri* who were still unable to prevent the BR from assassinating the chief of political police, came close to the ultimate terrorist scenario: 'dominated by fear, its people literally immobilized in a state of siege'.

The level of public discontent and the weakness of the state go some way to explaining the genuinely alarming impact of terrorism in Italy, but the case of Germany was plainly different. The upsurge of indiscriminate terror in the 1970s led by two small organizations—the communist 'Baader-Meinhof gang' (named the RAF (see [Chapter 2](#)), Red Army Group, as a gesture of respect for the 'Japanese Red Army group') and the anarchist B2J (see [Chapter 2](#)), named after the day (2nd June 1967) on which the police killed a student protester during the visit of the Shah of Iran—needs still more careful explanation. The central link between the two countries was, of course, the historical legacy of fascism and Nazism, which drove a wedge between the German postwar generation and their parents and made young people 'hypersensitive towards all authoritarian structures in society'. Instead, German youth culture turned towards America, and the resulting cocktail pervades the famous memoir written by 'Bommi' (Michael) Baumann in 1975 after he gave up his beloved bombs and left B2J: *Wie alles anfing*—'how it all began'—translated into English as *Terror or Love?* (1979). For Baumann, bombs and Hare Krishna seem to have been equally enjoyable—even playful—ways of getting at the system.

How typical was Baumann? Unlike the leading thinkers and activists of the RAF, Ulrike Meinhof, Gudrun Ensslin, and Horst Mahler—or indeed Renato Curcio of the BR—he was not a middle-class student (he called them 'bookworms' and said he 'could never really get close to' their world). He preferred the less ideological counter-culture of 'commune K.1', a classic manifestation of 1960s hippiedom. He had given up work in disgust at the sheer banality of everyday life—'this mindless activity just to get your old age pension'. He was untypical, too, in not being recruited through a friendship network. (At least 843 out of 1,214 recruits to the much larger BR identified in one study already had a friend in the organization, and of these three-quarters had more than one, and nearly half had over seven.)



But Baumann's account crucially registers the catalytic impact of the collective experiences of 1968, the huge antagonism generated on the left by the tone—and dishonesty—of the right-wing press (witness Baumann's fury when Hanns-Martin Schleyer, a former Nazi, kidnapped and killed by the RAF in 1977, was portrayed by the press as an innocent victim), and the potent inspiration of foreign guerrilla/terrorist movements. In the chapter entitled 'Tupamaros West Berlin', we witness the dramatic militarization of his group after a visit to the Popular Front for the Liberation of Palestine (PFLP) training camp in Lebanon. He also vividly conveys the sheer excitement of armed action. As his nickname suggests, he became fascinated by the use of explosives, and the closest studies made of these clandestine organizations underline the role of the continuous presence of weapons in the daily life of the group. This 'very special relationship with guns' was part of the distinctiveness which bound individuals to their comrades. The totality of individuals' commitment to the group's aims, and the binding effect of their detachment from normal life, have been repeatedly identified as the key dynamics of these very small organizations, which became effectively Burkean 'little platoons' (though they preferred unit names like 'cadre' or 'commando'). As Susan Stern of the Weathermen recalled, 'We were alone and isolated ... Ignoring the reality, we filled our minds with visions of the new underground.' Together they were 'contra mundum', and as their isolation from the public made it harder to see their actions as political successes, they increasingly envisaged their campaign in terms of 'war'. Repression often accelerated recruitment, as it did after the Moro incident, and the death of terrorist 'martyrs' in prison—Holger Meins and Ulrike Meinhof in 1976; Baader, Ensslin, and Raspe in 1977.

But all this still left a dizzying gap between the limited military means available and the ambitious aims of these groups. A constant mantra in 'Euroterrorist' literature was 'Never be deterred by the enormous dimensions of your own goals' (as the French group *Action Directe* told itself). Their targeting policy became increasingly destructive and indiscriminate, fitting the fundamental logic of the clandestine groups' existence: that normal moral values were part of the system that had to be overthrown, and upping the stakes—in effect exchanging the propaganda value of justification for greater shock value, and ensuring massive media coverage. Such publicity can disguise the absence of any corresponding shift in public opinion. Detachment from the real world may also, as the German philosopher Jürgen Habermas disapprovingly said, be heightened by other elements of 'youth culture': 'culture transmitted through electronic



gadgetry never quite loses its game character and superficiality, and contains the inherent danger of portraying the pseudo-world of entertainment as reality’.

So we may conclude that Western revolutionary terrorist groups have relied on pure terrorism mainly as a result of political weakness or marginality—even perhaps solipsism. In a political sense, then, the threat they have posed is minimal. When detached from the wider revolutionary movement, as Guevara and Debray pointed out, terrorism is self-defeating. The destructive tally of the RAF by the time it sank into inaction in the 1980s, for instance, was statistically as small as the group’s size might have predicted. Statistics, however, cannot convey the corrosive impact of their campaign on public morale and civic confidence in Germany, Italy, and beyond. They demonstrated that however resilient societies may be in objective terms, they remain psychologically fragile. For the Italian journalist Luigi Bonante, writing in 1978, ‘contemporary terrorism wounds that which seems to us to be one of the few judgments of value we all find ourselves in accord with—that the democratic system is the best’.